



THE BEGINNER'S GUIDE TO THE Body First Framework



*Simple Steps to Help Children and
Teens Regulate Emotions*

Understand your child's nervous system and
what to do in the moments that matter.

DR. CAELAN SOMA

The Body First Framework

Parenting can feel overwhelming when your child's emotions seem to spiral without warning. Meltdowns, shutdowns, and big reactions aren't signs of bad behavior, they're signs of an overwhelmed nervous system. When we learn to respond to that, everything starts to shift. When your child is stressed, behavior is not a choice, it is a signal. This is why consequences, lectures or corrections don't work and can make things worse.

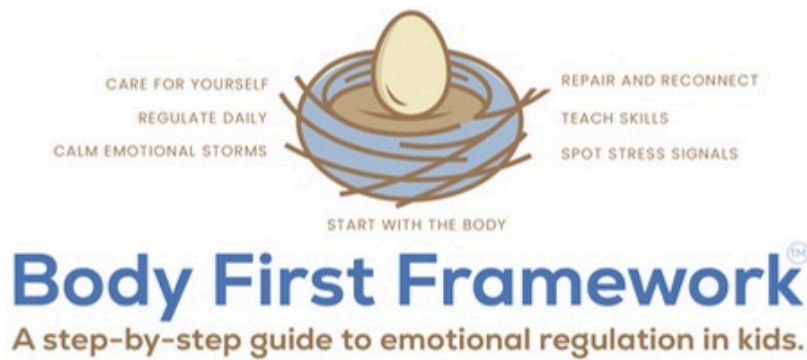
What behavior might be communicating

Meltdowns → an overwhelmed nervous system

Defiance → loss of control/protection response

Shutdown → nervous system collapse

When you shift from, "What is wrong with my child?" to "What is their nervous system telling me?" your response will begin to change.



The Body First Framework helps you understand what's happening inside your child's body so you can respond in ways that truly help. When children feel safe and connected, their bodies calm. Then, they listen, learn, and manage emotions.

Inside this guide, you'll find simple, practical steps to spot stress early, support your child through emotional moments, and build everyday regulation habits that strengthen resilience over time.

Regulation starts in the body.

To learn more [The Body First Framework for Parents: Practical Steps to Help Kids and Teens Regulate Emotions and Behavior](#), a self-paced online course with video and audio modules is available.

01 Start with body

Big feelings don't start as behavior. They start in the body. Before yelling, refusal, tears, or shutdowns, a child's nervous system is already working overtime to handle stress.

What looks like "overreacting" is usually a body that feels overwhelmed and unsafe.

A meltdown isn't misbehavior. It's a nervous system overload. When the body goes into stress mode, thinking skills go offline. Your child isn't choosing to fall apart, their system is doing its best to cope with more than it can handle.

That's why the first step is not correcting behavior.
The first step is helping the body feel safe.



Body Clues Cheat Sheet

Signs your child's nervous system is overwhelmed

Fast & Loud Clues

- Yelling or screaming
- Crying quickly
- Clenched fists or jaw
- Pacing or restless movement
- Arguing over small things

Quiet & Shut-Down Clues

- Zoning out
- Refusing to talk
- Hiding or avoiding
- Going limp or slumping
- Saying "I don't care"

Early Stress Signals

- Sudden silliness or hyperactivity
- Irritability
- Complaining about small discomforts
- Trouble with transitions
- Becoming unusually clingy

What to do

1 Pause before responding. Your calm body helps their calm body.

2 Lower your voice and slow your movements. A softer presence signals safety. Use fewer words

3 Move closer (if they accept comfort). Connection regulates the nervous system.

4 Focus on settling, not on solving.

What NOT to Say

"Calm down right now."

"Stop being dramatic."

"You're fine."

"Why are you acting like this?"

02

Spot stress signals early



66
Early support is not giving in, it is smart prevention

Emotional storms rarely come out of nowhere.

They build quietly.

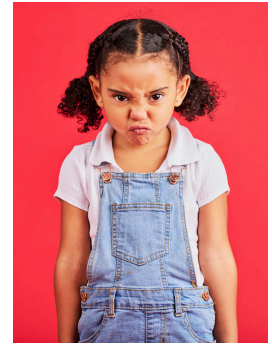
Small changes in your child's mood, energy, or behavior are often early warning signs that their stress is rising. When you catch these signals early, you can step in before emotions spill over into meltdowns or shutdowns.

Think of it like noticing dark clouds before a thunderstorm.

Early support is easier, gentler, and more effective.

Early warning signs

- Getting frustrated faster than usual
- Arguing or saying “no” to simple requests
- Becoming unusually silly or hyper
- Complaining about minor discomforts
- Avoiding tasks they can usually handle
- Increased clinginess
- Trouble with transitions
- Changes in tone, posture, or facial expression



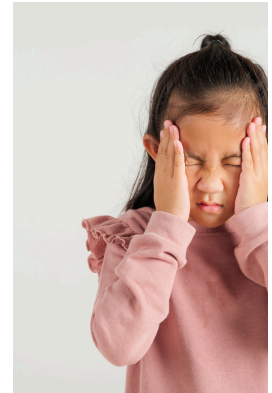
Quick wins that make a difference

- Meet physical needs: offer water, snack or movement
- Reduce demands and lower expectations
- Increase connection: Sit nearby, gentle touch
- Name what you notice: “You’re having a hard time.”



Why this matters

Catching stress early helps your child stay within a manageable emotional range. It prevents nervous system overload and teaches children that support is available before things feel out of control.



*You’re not just preventing meltdowns.
You’re teaching regulation skills for life.*



03

Calm emotional storms

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*When the storm passes, your child returns to a place where
learning and problem-solving are possible.*

But first, they need you to help their body feel safe.

Co-regulation

When emotions explode, learning stops. In the middle of a meltdown or shutdown, your child's thinking brain is offline. Reasoning, consequences, lectures, and problem-solving won't work, not because your child is refusing, but because their nervous system is overwhelmed. You can't teach during a storm. Calm before teaching. In intense emotional moments, your child doesn't need fixing.

They need regulation through **co-regulation**.

Stay Physically Present

Sit nearby. Stay close. Presence reduces fear and isolation.

Calm Your Own Body First

Slow your breathing. Relax your shoulders.

A regulated adult helps regulate a child.

Offer Gentle Connection

A soft tone. A comforting touch (if welcomed). Quiet reassurance.

Use Fewer Words

When stress is high, language can overwhelm.

What matters most

- ✓ Being present matters more than fixing
- ✓ Safety matters more than solutions
- ✓ Connection matters more than correction

Why this feels hard

Most of us were not responded to this way as children. So, in these moments your own nervous system may feel activated too.

Urgency, frustration or the need to fix it quickly. This is NOT a failure. It is part of the process.

Example: Child throws something

Response A:

Stop that right now! (escalates)

Response B:

Pause, sit nearby and say,
Something feels really big right now. Child starts to settle.



Reflect

- 1 What does your child do when they are overwhelmed?
- 2 What do you usually do in response?
- 3 What might shift if you slowed this moment down?

04 Teach skills (after calm)

The best teaching moments happen after the storm has passed. When your child is calm, their brain is open to learning. This is when new skills can take root and grow. Trying to teach during emotional overwhelm is like trying to write on water, nothing sticks. Regulation first. Learning second.

Why Timing Matters

Once your child feels safe and settled

- They can listen without feeling threatened
- They can think more clearly
- They can reflect on what happened
- They can practice doing things differently next time



Skills that grow through calm experiences

Emotional Literacy

Help children name and understand their feelings.

“You seemed really frustrated when that happened.”

“I wonder if you felt left out.”

When kids can name feelings, those feelings become less overwhelming.

Problem-solving

Guide children to think through what happened and what might help next time.

“What made that moment hard?”

“What could we try if it happens again?”

This builds confidence and coping skills.



Children don't learn regulation from punishment. They need to:

- 1 Feel Safe
- 2 Practice skills
- 3 Have supportive adults guide them

05

Regulate daily



Small daily supports create a stronger foundation for emotional resilience.

Regulation isn't only something we do during hard moments. It's something we build every day. Just like eating healthy and getting exercise keeps the body strong, daily regulation habits keep the nervous system balanced and better able to handle stress. The more supported your child's body feels throughout the day, the fewer emotional storms you'll see. Regulation is preventative, not just reactive.

A well-regulated nervous system:

- Handles frustration more easily
- Recovers from stress faster
- Thinks more clearly under pressure
- Experiences fewer meltdowns and shutdowns

Every day nervous system care

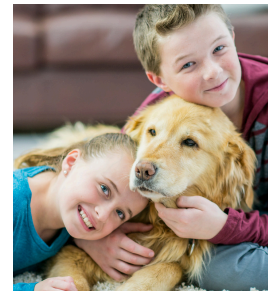
Sleep

Rest restores the brain and body.
Tired nervous systems struggle to cope.
Consistent bedtimes and calming nighttime routines make a big difference.



Movement/Play

Physical activity releases built-up stress and helps regulate mood and reset the nervous system.



Nourishment

Balanced meals and steady energy support emotional stability.

Connection

Moments of warmth and attention help children feel safe and secure.



Predictable Routines

Knowing what to expect helps children feel safe.

Small moments matter most. Regulation doesn't require perfection. These small, repeated moments build resilience over time.



06

Repair and reconnect

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*Rupture is inevitable. Repair is powerful.
And reconnection teaches children that love is stronger than
hard moments.*

Repair and reconnect

No family gets it right all the time. Conflict, missteps, and emotional blow-ups happen in every relationship, even loving and connected ones. These moments are called ruptures, and they are a normal part of being human. What builds emotional security isn't perfection. It's repair. When stress runs high, everyone's nervous system can become overwhelmed children and adults. Voices rise. Feelings get hurt. Disconnection happens. Repair teaches children something powerful: Relationships can bend without breaking.

Moments of reconnection show children they are safe, loved, and not alone — even after hard interactions. When adults take responsibility, children learn that mistakes are manageable and relationships can heal.

A simple apology teaches:

- It's safe to admit mistakes
- Strong feelings can be handled
- Repair is part of healthy relationships

You're not losing authority.
You're modeling emotional strength.

Repair doesn't need to be long or perfect.
Simple, sincere words matter most.

- ✓ *That was really hard for both of us.*
- ✓ *I am sorry for raising my voice.*
- ✓ *We are okay. Let's start fresh.*

07 *Care for yourself*

Your nervous system sets the tone. Children naturally look to adults for cues about safety. When you're calm, their bodies feel safer. When you're overwhelmed, they feel it too. Dysregulation is contagious, but so is calm. Taking care of yourself isn't selfish. It's one of the most powerful ways you support your child's emotional regulation. When stress rises:

- Children sense tension in tone and body language.
- Adult reactions can either escalate or settle the moment.
- A calm presence helps children recover faster.

You don't have to be perfectly calm. You just need to be aware and willing to reset.



Simple ways to reset your nervous system

60 second reset breath

Slow inhale through your nose.

Long, steady exhale through your mouth.

Repeat for one minute.

Longer exhales signal safety to the nervous system.

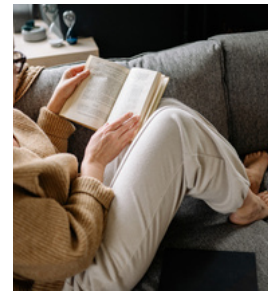


Grounding

Feel your feet on the floor.

Notice five things you can see.

Hold something cool or textured.



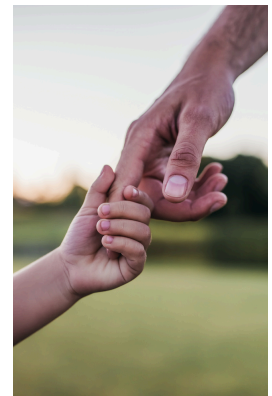
Lower expectations

Don't rush to fix, focus on regulation.

Movement

Take a short walk, stretch your arms overhead, or roll your shoulders.

Movement releases built-up tension and helps your body settle.

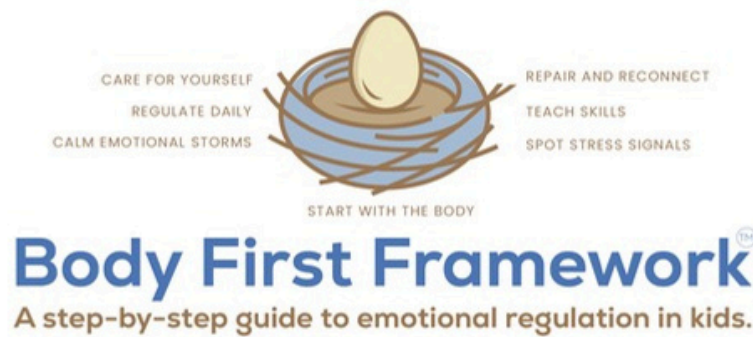


You don't have to be a perfect parent.

You just need to return to calm, again and again.

Your regulation is the foundation your child builds on.

Putting it all together



Emotional regulation grows through safety, connection, and practice. The Body First Framework begins by understanding what's happening inside your child's body, noticing stress early, and helping calm emotional storms through co-regulation. Once calm returns, children can learn skills like naming feelings, solving problems, and thinking flexibly. Daily regulation habits strengthen the nervous system, repair rebuilds connection when things get messy, and your own regulation helps set the tone. When we start with the body, we create the safety children need to grow, learn, and handle life's big emotions.

This guide ehlpes you begin to see and respond differently. The course walks you through the framework step-by-step how to apply this across different situations, ages, and patterns over time.



drcaelansoma@gmail.com
www.doctorcae.com

What do I actually do in real life?



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Online Course

[The Body First Framework for Parents:
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Email drcaelansoma@gmail.com

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